In November 1950, Sardar Patel and Pandit Nehru had a famous exchange of views on how to approach China. Much has changed since, mostly to India's disadvantage. The key issues – realism versus optimism and bilateralism versus globalism – remain as relevant today as then. Striking a judicious balance is not necessarily easier with the passage of time. But the past also tells us that there is always room for strategy and vision if we are to go beyond politics and constraints. More than on any other relationship in the world today, the long view must prevail.

In chess, an 'Indian Defence' is a popular opening for those who find themselves playing black. And indeed, playing black has been the standard Indian strategic posture. As life becomes complicated, there are learnings in what Aron Nimzowitsch introduced to the game a century ago. Known as the 'Nimzo-Indian Defence', he imaginatively created latitude for the black; and therein lies a lesson.